

L E S S O N 03

The Truth About What Really Saves You

1: Sin and Salvation

Scripture Focus: *John 3:16 · Romans 5:8 · 2 Corinthians 5:21 · Ephesians 2:8-9*

Many people believe salvation must be earned through good works or religious observance. But Scripture is clear: salvation is a gift. God loved us while we were still sinners, Jesus became our substitute on the cross, and we are saved solely by grace through faith — not by anything we do.

BY THE END

You Will...

A	Explain the central discipleship issue in your own words.
B	Connect the main truth to John 3:16 and Romans 5:8 and 2 Corinthians 5:21 and Ephesians 2:8-9.
C	Name one way this truth should shape your thinking, obedience, prayer, or witness.

VOCABULARY

Key Terms

THEME	STUDY NOTE
Sin	Any failure to love, trust, worship, and obey God as He deserves; sin separates people from God and requires divine rescue.

THEME	STUDY NOTE
Salvation	God's gracious rescue of sinners through the finished work of Christ, received by faith rather than earned by works.
Faith	Trusting God's Word and relying on Christ rather than self, merit, feeling, or religious performance.
Grace	God's unearned favor toward sinners, shown supremely in Christ and active in the believer's growth.
Scripture	God's written Word, authoritative and sufficient for knowing Him, understanding salvation, and walking faithfully.

TEACHING NOTES

I. The Main Question

Christian discipleship begins with learning to see salvation by grace through faith from Scripture rather than from instinct, habit, or surrounding culture. The goal is not simply to collect religious information, but to have the mind, conscience, and affections trained by God's Word. Many people believe salvation must be earned through good works or religious observance. But Scripture is clear: salvation is a gift. God loved us while we were still sinners, Jesus became our substitute on the cross, and we are saved solely by grace through faith — not by anything we do.

A growing Christian asks: what does God require me to believe, reject, receive, or practice? Real maturity includes a clearer love for Christ, a humbler view of self, and a more faithful step of obedience.

II. What Scripture Says

John 3:16 and Romans 5:8 and 2 Corinthians 5:21 and Ephesians 2:8-9 provide the biblical anchor. These passages keep the discussion tied to God's Word and give the learner a stable foundation for reflection. By his wounds, you have been healed." 2 Corinthians 5:21 says, "For our sake, he made him," that's Jesus, "to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him, Jesus Christ, we might become the righteousness of God.

Before moving too quickly to application, read the references slowly. Ask what the passage reveals about God, what it says about the human condition, what it commands or promises, and how it points the believer back to Christ. Scripture sets the agenda; Christian reflection follows where God has spoken.

III. The Doctrine Explained

Doctrine matters because discipleship is built on truth. Maybe they do good works or they give a lot of money to the church or they go to shelters and feed the homeless or they do these acts of what we call righteousness. Doctrine is not a detached category for specialists; it names what every Christian is learning to believe, confess, defend, and practice.

Write the doctrine in your own words. Then ask how it fits into the larger story of Scripture: creation, fall, redemption, and Christian growth. A doctrine has been understood more deeply when it begins to reshape worship, repentance, assurance, humility, courage, and love.

SCRIPTURE SPOTLIGHT

John 3:16

John 3:16 should be read as more than a proof text. It gives the subject its center of gravity and keeps Christian thinking inside God's revealed Word rather than personal opinion.

Read John 3:16 first, then read Romans 5:8 and 2 Corinthians 5:21 and Ephesians 2:8-9. Notice how the passages work together: one may name the doctrine, another may show its consequence, and another may press the believer toward obedience.

I'm right there with you, but scripture reveals to us that Jesus Christ is perfectly fully God.

Study the passage:

1. *What does this passage teach about God, Christ, humanity, sin, grace, or obedience?*

2. What word or phrase should control how you understand this truth?
3. How would this passage help a newer believer think more clearly?

FRAMEWORK

Biblical Salvation vs. Common Assumption

BIBLICAL CATEGORY	COMMON CONFUSION
God defines the human problem before He reveals the rescue.	Sin is treated as a small mistake or comparison with other people.
Grace is received by faith because Christ has accomplished salvation.	Salvation is treated as something earned by moral effort.
Repentance and faith belong together in the believer's response.	Repentance is reduced to feeling bad or trying harder.

PAUSE & REFLECT

Before moving on, write one sentence answering this: where does salvation by grace through faith most need to become clearer or more obedient in your own life?

IV. Common Confusion

Common confusion usually begins when a biblical truth is reduced to a slogan, separated from its context, or filtered through personal experience. things that they think if I do these things at the end of the day there's these giant scales in the sky and if I do enough good it's going to outweigh the bad. New believers especially need help seeing the difference between a biblical category and a half-true assumption.

When confusion appears, do not answer it only with opinion. Return to the text, define your terms, and make careful distinctions. Stability grows as hard questions are brought patiently under Scripture.

V. Why This Matters for Discipleship

Truth becomes fruitful when it forms the disciple. It says, He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. Biblical

teaching should train the believer to worship, repent, trust, forgive, serve, pray, resist sin, and speak the gospel with clarity.

Ask where this truth should create maturity. Does it deepen assurance? Correct pride? Encourage obedience? Make Scripture more central? Strengthen witness? The question is not merely whether the content is understood, but what kind of disciple the truth is forming.

VI. How This Changes Daily Life

Salvation by grace through faith belongs in ordinary Christian life, not merely in a notebook. Maybe they do good works or they give a lot of money to the church or they go to shelters and feed the homeless or they do these acts of what we call righteousness. Identify one real setting where the truth should matter: a conversation, a temptation, a fear, a decision, a family moment, a church responsibility, or a private habit.

Growing in grace often happens through small, repeated acts of faithfulness. Choose one practice for this week that is concrete enough to obey, simple enough to remember, and biblical enough to strengthen your walk with Christ.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **salvation by grace through faith should train the way a believer thinks, worships, and obeys.**
- **Scripture must set the terms before personal experience, church culture, or instinct is allowed to define the issue.**
- **We are saved solely by God's grace through faith in Jesus Christ.**
- **Christian maturity grows as doctrine moves from information into prayer, repentance, assurance, service, witness, and daily faithfulness.**

REFLECTION

Questions for the Lesson

1. *What should become clearer in your thinking about salvation by grace through faith?*

2. *Where does this truth correct a common misunderstanding or shallow habit?*

3. *What is one concrete step of obedience, prayer, study, or conversation you should take this week?*

PUT INTO PRACTICE

A Discipleship Conversation

Imagine a newer believer asks you about salvation by grace through faith. They are not asking for a lecture; they need a patient, Scripture-shaped answer that helps them trust Christ and take one faithful next step.

Your Task

1. Use John 3:16 to write a simple, biblical answer in your own words.

2. Name one practical step you would encourage this person to take this week.

3. Write one prayer request that fits the truth and the situation.
